📖 SSC CGL — English Grammar Rules Tables

Active ↔ Passive · Direct ↔ Indirect · Error Spotting — rule → formula → example, with authentic PYQ-pattern questions (2021–2025).

Target post: ASO · Tier-I English · every example drawn from the repo's Voice/Narration & Error-Detection banks.

● Correct form ● Wrong form (trap) 🔴 High-repeat rule PYQ = actual repo question

> **How to use:** Each table is **Rule → Formula → Example (Active/Direct → Passive/Indirect)**. The (PYQ boxes are the exact questions from the repository's solved banks so you can see the rule tested the way SSC actually asks it.

1 · Active → Passive Voice — the 8 tenses 🔴 High Repeat

Core formula: `Object + correct form of BE + past participle (V₃) + by + agent`. Keep the **tense unchanged**; only the *be*-form changes.

TENSE	PASSIVE "BE" FORM	ACTIVE EXAMPLE	PASSIVE EXAMPLE	PYQ (REPO)
Simple Present	`is / am / are + V₃`	Every morning the senior editor, along with two junior assistants, reviews the manuscripts that authors submit from across the country.	Every morning the manuscripts that authors submit from across the country **are reviewed** by the senior editor along with two junior assistants.	**PYQ · Voice EASY Q1** Change to passive: "*She writes a letter.*" → **A letter is written by her.**
Present Continuous	`is / am / are being + V₃`	While the auditors examine last year's records, the finance team is preparing the revised budget that the board of directors requested in the previous meeting.	While last year's records are being examined by the auditors, the revised budget that the board of directors requested in the previous meeting **is being prepared** by the finance team.	**PYQ · Voice PYQ Q1** Passive of "*The chef is preparing a special dish.*" → **A special dish is being prepared by the chef.**
Present Perfect	`has / have been + V₃`	The government, together with several international agencies, has recently launched three welfare schemes that millions of families in rural districts have been waiting for.	Three welfare schemes that millions of families in rural districts have been waiting for **have recently been launched** by the government together with several international agencies.	**PYQ · Voice MEDIUM Q1** Passive of "*Someone has stolen my bicycle.*" → **My bicycle has been stolen.**
Simple Past	`was / were + V₃`	After the results were declared, the principal, in the presence of the parents and the visiting inspectors, awarded gold medals to the three students who had topped the examination.	After the results were declared, gold medals **were awarded** to the three students who had topped the examination by the principal, in the presence of the parents and the visiting inspectors.	**PYQ · Voice EASY Q4** Passive of "*He opened the door.*" → **The door was opened by him.**
Past Continuous	`was / were being + V₃`	When the earthquake struck at midnight, the workers were still repairing the old bridge that connected the two villages separated by the river.	When the earthquake struck at midnight, the old bridge that connected the two villages separated by the river **was still being repaired** by the workers.	**PYQ · Voice HARD Q2** Passive of "*They were repairing the road when I passed by.*" → **The road was being repaired when I passed by.**

TENSE	PASSIVE "BE" FORM	ACTIVE EXAMPLE	PASSIVE EXAMPLE	PYQ (REPO)
Simple Future	`will be + V₃`	Once the verification is complete, the selection committee will announce the final list of candidates who have qualified for the interview round next week.	Once the verification is complete, the final list of candidates who have qualified for the interview round **will be announced** next week by the selection committee.	**PYQ · Voice MEDIUM Q4** Passive of *"The committee will announce the results."* → **The results will be announced by the committee.**
Modal (should/can/must)	`modal + be + V₃`	One should keep one's promises.	Promises **should be kept**.	**PYQ · Voice HARD Q4** Passive of *"One should keep one's promises."* → **Promises should be kept.**
Generic agent (drop agent)	`is / are + V₃`	People speak English all over the world.	English **is spoken** all over the world.	**PYQ · Voice MEDIUM Q6** Passive of *"People speak English all over the world."* → **English is spoken all over the world.** (drop "people")

2 · Passive Voice — traps & reverse (Passive → Active)

SITUATION	RULE	CORRECT	REVERSE / TRAP
Passive → Active	Match the tense back; passive "is being + V_3" ⇒ active "is + V-ing".	"A new bridge is being built by the government." → **The government is building a new bridge.**	Trap: "The government builds…" (wrong tense — simple, not continuous).
Perfect tenses only take "been"	has/have/had + **been** + V_3 — never "has + V_3".	has been completed	~~has completed~~ "…" is active, not passive.
No progressive in perfect passive	Present perfect passive is "has been + V_3", not "-ing".	My bicycle has been stolen.	~~is being stolen~~ mixes tenses.
Keep agent only if meaningful	Drop by-agent when it is people / one / someone / they (general).	English is spoken all over the world.	… (by people) — redundant, omit.

2b · Passive Voice — advanced & harder tenses

🔴 Mock-test level

These are the tenses that separate 20/25 from full marks. Note the two **"only" rules**: perfect tenses insert `been`; future/modal insert `be`. Continuous perfects and infinitives usually stay active in the exam.

TENSE	PASSIVE "BE" FORM	ACTIVE EXAMPLE	PASSIVE EXAMPLE	REVERSE
Past Perfect	`had been + V₃`	She had written the report.	The report **had been written** by her.	had been + V_3
Future Continuous	`will be + V-ing → (rare; kept active)`	They will be painting the wall.	The wall will be being painted. (usually avoided)	Exam trap.

TENSE	PASSIVE "BE" FORM	ACTIVE EXAMPLE	PASSIVE EXAMPLE	REVERSE
Future Perfect	`will have been + V₃ + time clause`	They will have translated the manuscript by the time the committee submits its report.	The manuscript **will have been translated** by the time the committee submits its final report.	will have + V_3 ⇄ clause
Modal Perfect	`modal + have been + V₃`	He must have finished the task.	The task **must have been finished** by him.	must + V_3
Infinitive	`to be + V₃`	I have a letter to write.	I have a letter **to be written**.	to be + V_3
Imperative	`Let + object + be + V₃`	Close the door.	**Let the door be closed.**	Let … object + be + V_3

Future Perfect worked example (from an SSC CGL mock, T-I English):
Passive given: "*…will have been translated by the time the review committee submits its final report.*"
Correct active: "*They will have translated the manuscript by the time the review committee submits its final report.*"
Why the traps fail: ~~will translate~~ = simple future (wrong tense) · ~~have translated~~ = present perfect (wrong tense) · any option that reorders the "by the time…" clause changes the meaning.
Rule: Future-perfect passive `will have been + V₃` ⇄ active `will have + V₃` — the "will have" is the anchor; never drop to "will" or "have".

3 · Direct → Indirect Speech — the change-rules

High Repeat

Three things always change when the reporting verb is **past**: (1) tense back-shifts, (2) pronouns adjust to the reporter, (3) time/place words shift.

3a · Tense back-shift

DIRECT TENSE	→	INDIRECT TENSE	EXAMPLE (FROM REPO)
Simple Present	→	Simple Past	"I am tired." → He said that he **was** tired.
Present Continuous	→	Past Continuous	"Are you coming?" → asked if she **was coming**.
Present Perfect	→	Past Perfect	"I have finished now." → she **had finished** … then.
Simple Past	→	Past Perfect	"Where do you live?" → asked where I **lived**.
will	→	would	"I will help you." → said she **would** help me.
may	→	might	"May God bless you!" → prayed God **might** bless me.

3b · Time / place / pronoun shifts

DIRECT	→	INDIRECT	DIRECT	→	INDIRECT
now	→	then	this	→	that

DIRECT	→	INDIRECT	DIRECT	→	INDIRECT
today	→	that day	here	→	there
tomorrow	→	the next day	ago	→	before
yesterday	→	the previous day	these	→	those
I / we	→	he / she / they	you	→	me / him (per sense)

4 · Narration by sentence type — reporting verb & connector

The reporting verb changes with the sentence's purpose. This is the most-tested distinction in the PYQ bank.

SENTENCE TYPE	REPORTING VERB	CONNECTOR / PATTERN	DIRECT → INDIRECT EXAMPLE (REPO PYQ)
Statement	said / told	that + clause	"I am tired." → He said that he was tired.
Wh-question	asked	asked + wh-word + statement order (drop do/did)	"Where do you live?" → He asked me where I lived.
Yes/No question	asked	asked + if / whether + clause	"Are you coming with me?" → He asked her if she was coming with him.
Command (order)	ordered	ordered + obj + to + V_1	"March forward." → The officer ordered the soldiers to march forward.
Request (polite)	requested	requested + obj + to + V_1 ("please" → requested)	"Please close the window." → She requested me to close the window.
Negative command	ordered / forbade	+ not + to + V_1	"Do not make noise." → The teacher ordered not to make noise.
Exclamation	exclaimed	that + … very …	"What a beautiful sight it is!" → He exclaimed that it was a very beautiful sight.
Wish / prayer (optative)	prayed / wished	prayed that + might	"May God bless you!" → He prayed that God might bless me.

5 · Error Spotting — high-yield rules

High Repeat

The "more subjects = more chaos" strategy: SSC lengthens the sentence and stuffs 3–4 nouns between the real subject and the verb so your ear agrees the verb with the **nearest** noun instead of the **true** one. **Fix:** mentally delete everything between commas / inside "who/which" clauses, strip it down to **subject + verb**, then check agreement. The verb answers to the head-noun only.

Check in this order: **subject–verb agreement** → **tense** → **preposition** → **article** → **pronoun/comparative**. Read the whole sentence — "No error" is sometimes correct.

RULE	WHAT TO WATCH	WRONG ✗	CORRECT ✓	LONG EXAM-GRADE SENTENCE / PYQ
"One of..." is singular	Subject is "One", not the plural noun after it.	~~One of my friends are going~~	One of my friends is going	"One of the many candidates for the post were found ineligible during verification." → subject is **One** → *was*. PYQ (Error EASY Q1): "One of my friends are going" → is going.
"along with / with" phrase	Phrase between commas doesn't change the number.	~~The boy ... were playing~~	The boy ... was playing	"The captain of the team, along with the reserve players, were confident before the season." → subject is **captain** → *was*. PYQ (Error EASY Q3): "The boy along with his friends were playing" → was playing.
Each / Every / Neither = singular	Take a singular verb & singular pronoun.	~~Each of the students have~~	Each of the students has	"Each of the officers, managers ... attended the annual conference and submit their feedback." → **Each ... asked**. PYQ (Error EASY Q6): "Each of the students have submitted" → has submitted.
"The number of" = singular	vs "A number of" = plural.	~~The number of applicants have increased~~	The number of applicants has increased	"The number of students appearing for competitive examinations across the northern states have risen over the last decade." → **"The number of"** → **has risen**. PYQ (Error HARD Q2): "The number of applicants have increased" → has increased.
since vs for	since = point in time; for = period.	~~working here since five years~~	working here for five years	"My uncle, who retired from the farm near the hills, has been living there twelve years." → period → **for**. PYQ (Error EASY Q5): "since five years" → for five years.
Double comparative	Never "more + -er".	~~He is more taller than his brother~~	He is taller than his brother	"Although he had trained for months, he proved to be more stronger than his seasoned rivals." → **stronger**. PYQ (Error EASY Q4): "more taller than his brother" → taller.
Uncountable nouns	advice/information/furniture — no "a/an", no -s.	~~He gave me an advice~~	He gave me a piece of advice	"The professor, before he left, gave the students many useful advice and informations about the upcoming exam." → **useful advice and important information**. PYQ (Error MEDIUM Q3): "an advice" → a piece of advice.
Collective noun (act individually)	jury/committee take plural verb when divided.	~~The jury was divided in their opinion~~	The jury were divided in their opinion	"The committee, which had met to discuss the disputed proposal, were divided among themselves over the final decision." → **were divided**. PYQ (Error PYQ Q3): "The jury was divided in their opinion" → were divided.
"one of those ... who"	Verb agrees with plural noun, not "one".	~~one of those students who always works~~	one of those students who always work	"He is one of those rare leaders who admit a mistake and always listen to the members of the team." → **who ... listen**, not hesitate. PYQ (Error HARD Q4): "one of those students who always works" → work.

6 · Correlative pairs & preposition partners

Memorise these — they are pure recall marks in every SSC paper.

6a · Correlative pairs (fixed connectors)

CORRECT PAIR	WRONG (TRAP)	EXAMPLE / PYQ
No sooner ... **than**	~~No sooner ... when~~	"No sooner did the bell ring **than** the children rushed out." (Error HARD Q1)
Hardly / Scarcely ... **when**	~~Hardly ... than~~	"Scarcely had I reached the station **when** the train left." (Error PYQ / HARD Q5)

CORRECT PAIR	WRONG (TRAP)	EXAMPLE / PYQ
Neither … **nor**	~~Neither … or~~	Verb agrees with the **nearer** subject. "Neither the manager nor the employees **were** present."
Either … **or**	~~Either … nor~~	"Either the boy or his friends **are** … " (verb → nearer subject).
Not only … **but also**	~~Not only … but~~	Keep both halves parallel.

6b · Preposition partners (fixed)

CORRECT	WRONG (TRAP)	PYQ (REPO)
senior **to**	~~senior than~~	"She is senior ~~than me~~" → senior to me. (Error MEDIUM Q7)
prefer … **to**	~~prefer … than~~	"She prefers reading ~~than~~ watching TV" → to watching. (Error PYQ Q4)
good **at**	~~good in~~	"Both sisters are good ~~in~~ mathematics" → good at. (Error MEDIUM Q6)
married **to**	~~married with~~	She is married to him.
superior **to**	~~superior than~~	This model is superior to that one.

★ Quick Recall — the night-before checklist

TOPIC	THE ONE THING TO REMEMBER
Passive voice	Object + **correct BE** + V_3 + by agent; match BE to the **original tense**; perfect always uses "been", future/modal uses "be".
Passive → Active	Reverse the BE-form back to the same tense (is being → is + V-ing).
Indirect speech	Past reporting verb ⇒ back-shift tense, change pronouns, shift now→then / here→there.
Narration verb	asked (question), ordered/requested (command), exclaimed (!), prayed (wish).
Error — agreement	Find the **real subject**; ignore phrases between commas; "One of / Each / The number of / Neither" = singular.
Error — prepositions	senior/prefer/superior/junior **to**; good **at**; married **to**.
Error — pairs	No sooner…**than**; Hardly/Scarcely…**when**; Neither…**nor**.
Error — misc	No double comparative (more taller ✗); uncountables take no "a/an" (an advice ✗); "since" = point, "for" = period.

Exam reflex: In voice, first name the **tense** — the passive writes itself. In narration, first name the **sentence type** — it fixes the reporting verb. In error spotting, first find the **true subject** — most errors are agreement.